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FCE (FIRST CERTIFICATE IN ENGLISH) PREPARATION COURSE

First edition

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Vocabulary reference

Page numbers indicate where you will see each item in **NEW First Certificate Gold**. The letter R means the phrase is in the recording.

The grammar of multi-word verbs

These do not normally have an article before them.

Verbs + particle + preposition

1 try to pick(sb up (page viii)

eg I'm trying to pick him up.

2 be getting over (page viii)

eg **She's getting over an illness.**

The verb be is included in the separable. This type is very seldom used with *to*.

Verbs + particle + object / verb + object + particle

3 catch up with(sb (page ix)

eg **We caught up with our friend.**

4 buy (some time) (page ix)

eg **They're trying to buy time.**

My remembrance **bought with** the object on the end (not split).

Verbs + preposition + object (prepositional verb)

5 see to (page x)

eg **I'll see to your request.**

6 come across (as) + adj (page x)

eg **He comes across as very confident.**

The object is not put between the verb and preposition.

Verbs + particle + noun + object (directional verbs)

7 look down on(sb (page xi)

eg **They look down on others.**

8 look down at sb (page xi)

eg **He looked down at the tiny house.**

The object is put after the particle but before the preposition.

Verbs with one particle

9 carry out (page 13) eg We've carried out surveys.

10 break down (page 15) eg The car broke down in the street.

11 come across (page 15) eg We came across a poster.

12 drive through (page 15) eg I drove through the red lights.

13 give up (page 15) eg Don't give up now!

Some verbs with only one particle are separable. Some are not.

Verbs with two particles

14 come up with sth (page 16) eg. We came up with some good ideas.

15 work out (page 16) eg. It didn't work out.

16 work well with sb / sth (page 16) eg. The company works well with some good suppliers.

Some verbs are used with two particles. The company work out is transitive. Only work with is not used as a separable verb; it is used with a complete prepositional phrase. Not all verbs are separable.

Verbs with one or two particles

17 find out (page 17) eg. I found out some interesting facts.

18 stand up to(sb (page 17) eg. don't stand up to him.

Some verbs can be used with one or two particles. The objects can go between the particle(s) (NOT do as the past tense of do): stand up to sb.

Verb + adverb

19 find out about sth (page 18) eg Find out about my modern project.

20 run out of sth (page 18) eg. We ran out of milk.

Some verbs are used with an adverb.

Verb and object (not used with particle or preposition)

21 accept (page 18) eg I accept your suggestion.

22 answer (page 18) eg Please answer my question.

Some verbs are used only with an object.



Vocabulary reference



Page numbers indicate where you will see each item in **NEW First Certificate Gold**. The letter **a** means that the phrase is in the recording.

The grammar of multi-word verbs

These are the main types of multi-word verbs.

1

Verb + particle: phrasal verbs

- We'll go ahead and order.
- I'm passing through again.

16 particle phrasal verbs

The particle is placed after the verb. The key is to remember which particles are used.

• 2

• Verb + particle + object (noun): object + particle

- We've gone over it.
- My grandmother brought me up.
- 76 two-part phrasal verbs
- The particle goes between the verb and the object or is put after the object: e.g. I read over the report or I read the report over.

3

Verb + preposition + object (prepositional verbs)

- I went along with what she said.
- I came across a lot of phrasal verbs.

91 verbs taking one or two prepositions

4

Verb + particle + preposition + object (prepositional verbs)

- He came up with an idea.
- Look down on me.

15 verbs (13 with three prepositional parts, two with two prepositional parts)

- **Verb + infinitive**
- **In this book the letter z before a verb is followed by bare infinitives, e.g. I'll try to finish by three.**
- **Verb (1, 2 or 3rd person) + to + infinitive is used:**
- **In formal or neutral English after expressions such as: it's a pity, I'd prefer, I (don't) want, would like, offer, choose, agree, seem, promise, plan, manage**
- **After why and where: I don't know where to go.**
- **Verb + -ing is used:**
- **after enjoy, finish, mind, miss, practise, suggest.**

-ing (verb) and to (verb): verbs are carrying out something

-ing (verb) tells (1) 173 continuous: He's writing an important letter.

-ing (verb) usually comes after expressions such as:

I can't stand, it's (no) good, worth, suggest, finish, mind, enjoy, give up, it's no use, I feel like:

I can't stand waiting for the bus.

to (verb) tells (2) an action or a planned activity. The company is going to sell the toy robots.

to (verb) is used with expressions such as: would like, would love, it's difficult or easy, want, need, be/decide/want/hope to do something in the future, too ... to + infinitive:

I'd like to live in the country.

Relative clauses

We use who (3) for a person: That is the girl who won second prize.

We use which (4) for a thing: This is the book which I bought yesterday.

We use that (5) for a person or a thing: It's that man over there.

We use whose (6) for possession.

It's a small village whose people are very friendly.

We use where (7) for place: That's where he grew up.

Gerund (noun) and infinitive (noun)

We use -ing (verb) as a noun (8) with verbs and expressions such as: admit, avoid, can't help, consider, dislike, fancy, finish, mind, need, recommend, suggest:

I don't mind waiting.

We use to + infinitive (noun) (9) with verbs and expressions such as: agree, arrange, choose, decide, demand, help, hope, learn, plan, pretend, refuse:

I hope to hear from you soon.

If clauses

If + present (10) is used for possible present and future situations:

If I see Tom, I'll give him your message.

If + past (11) is used for impossible present or future situations:

If I were you, I'd buy that jacket.

Vocabulary reference

Page numbers indicate where you will see each item in a New First Certificate Gold. The letter n means the phrase is in the recording.

The grammar of multi-word verbs

- **have to do something:** must do an action
- *I have to parking the car today.*
- **get something done:** cause
- *I got my bike repaired today.*
- The pipe got broken by the bullders.
- **want someone to do something:** want
- *I want my bike painted red.*
- **have something done:** have as someone else
- *I had my hair cut.*
- **have got to do something:** must
- *I've got to go now. I'm late for the airport.*
- **be / been doing something:** continuous action
- *I am still repairing my bike.*
- *I was fixing the car when it began to rain.*
- *I've been having fun these last few weekends.*
- **break down:** stop working
- *My bike broke down. I'll have to walk into town.*
- **boil over:** reach the point of boiling and spill over
- *The saucepan boiled over.*
- **burn out:** stop working, especially in a motor
- *The engine burned out.*
- **call off:** decide that an event will not happen
- *The tennis match was called off.*
- **can't cope (with):** deal with an unpleasant situation
- *I can't cope (with) my new job.*
- **carry on (with):** start again
- *Let's carry on (with) the conversation.*

- **carry out:** do as an order, system or arrange out
- *The manager carried out the instructions.*
- **catch on (to sth):** understand or achieve an im-improvement in sth
- *She didn't catch on to the teacher's suggestions. We soon caught on to the new computer system.*
- come across (sth): find, meet, encounter
- *I came across a good book by accident in the library.*
- **come up (with sth):** think of, invent
- *We came up with a good plan.*
- The company came up with a new computer.
- **end up (in sth):** finish in a particular situation
- *I ended up in hospital.*
- *You'll end up on your own with no one to help.*
- **face up (to sth):** deal with a problem, take on a challenge
- *I have to face up to all the work I've got to do.*
- We face up to our problems.
- **fall out (about sth):** start having problems
- *They fell out about who was responsible for the accident.*
- **find out (about sth):** discover
- *She found out about his new job by accident.*
- **get behind (sth):** 1) support
- *I really get behind the position the school is taking on this issue.*
- 2) become late with your work
- *I'm getting behind with my homework.*
- **get through (sth):** pass a test, exam or interview
- *I got through the exam easily.*
- *We got through the problem.*



Paper 2 Writing: general marking guidelines

For Parts of the Writing paper (or any exam paper), some markers, regardless the assessed domain(s) or guidelines follow ten basic marks, as well as a task-specific mark scheme for each question (or) in the paper.

Band 5

- addresses the question completely and makes some original points.
- Uses a wide range of grammatical structures at this level with almost no mistakes
- Uses a wide range of vocabulary appropriately.
- Uses clear paragraph structure and appropriate linking.
- Uses few direct 'quotes' from the rubrics without lifting/putting in their own words.

Band 4

- addresses the question, giving enough detail to be effective
- Uses a wide range of grammatical structures with some mistakes that have basic mistakes
- Uses a wide range of vocabulary, with some basic mistakes
- Uses clear paragraph structure and linking most of the time
- Has a number of ideas on the answer

Band 3

- Addresses the question
- Uses a satisfactory range of grammatical structures at this level, with some errors
- Uses a satisfactory range of vocabulary, with some errors in appropriacy
- Uses some linking or referencing words, with always clarity
- Mostly uses the right style for the type of writing, though there may be some lapses.
- Has a satisfactory effect on the reader

Band 2

- Does not answer the question fully, and/or is not always relevant to the question
- Uses a limited range of grammatical structures, with errors which sometimes make communication difficult
- Uses a limited range of vocabulary, with many errors and/or affects understanding
- Uses few or no linking words, or does not use them correctly
- Usually uses little or no referencing to other ideas or writing
- Has little understanding of the reader and does not communicate clearly

Band 1

- Omits some parts of the question and/or is irrelevant
- Uses an extremely range of grammatical structures, with many basic errors
- Does not use new ideas at all, with words that are present understandings
- Does not use linking words
- Does not demonstrate any understanding of the style and format needed for this type of writing
- Has little or no effect on the reader



Writing reference (Paper 2)

Contents

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Story	
Informal letter	
Article	
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Model writing: key sentences	inside back cover

Checklist

When writing for a paper 2, be sure to tick, check that you have used the appropriate:

- purpose(s)
- keywords in each part of the prompt
- correct style and suitable vocabulary
- different ways of expressing the same idea
- paragraphing (where necessary)
- spelling of words you are not sure how to spell?

Accuracy

- sentences – check order of pronouns, word order, articles, punctuation?

Range

Have you used:

- a variety of **grammatical structures**?
- a range of vocabulary and collocations?
- linkers and **time connects**?

Style

- Set the tone **by using appropriate style for the target**
- **writing a magazine article to make readers smile**
- **writing a formal letter to make a request**
- **writing a report as a serious analysis?**

Have you written a positive ending to your report and article?

Formal transactional letter

Be sure of a formal server, use pages 26, 45 and 140.

Task

You recently had a bad holiday at a large city which was lovely during summer but you visited in February. Write a letter to a local tour company and explain in detail your disappointment. Use 1 include lots of facts and the reasons behind these facts. Then-while a list a measures, regentations and 3 things that they could improve for next year's visitors.

Getaways

Enjoy a short holiday in the capital city!

We offer very stylish accommodation in 5 star, and brand new hotels in London.

Has emotional hooking words.

All rooms have their own bathroom and a view of the skyline.

Towns and sights are put first.

The price of £150 per person includes a touring bus ride a traditional British-style dinner and visit to the city's best sites. This will be a real holiday to

Clear information.

Has detailed facts.

remember!

Has positive final words!

Write a letter of between 120 and 180 words in 20-25 minutes. 'Do not' write any point addresses.

Model answer

DO open by saying why you are writing and thank them for their help.

DON'T make excuses or say you're embarrassed or urgent.

DO say how much you enjoyed it and why.

DO say when and where it was.

DON'T be rude or complain.

Dear Sir,

I am writing to explain about a short holiday I just enjoyed, which was organised by Citibreaks. I was devastated not to secretly tell you.

First, your advertisement attracted a lot in a circular card. However, when we saw it with my parents, they felt it was too expensive. Then, we asked to sell it with some money. Finally, we decided to get this point for you. It's a good idea and a golden opportunity. I had a lot of fun with not only family, but also two friends. It was an ideal holiday for us all. In addition, we spent the busy time happily with a little show up in the swim pool. I think we won't forget this good memory.

I also available for interview at any time. I can be contacted on (999) 12 3 4 21 after 6 pm, or by e-mail.

Thank you for remaining for my explanation. I look forward to hearing from you.

Yours faithfully,

Gabriella Danello

(formerly) Farietta

(173 words)

DO say why you've written and thank them again. Use formal expressions for future communication.

DON'T give too much detail - say anything from them.

DO you want anything from them.

SIGN your name or put your signature.

Useful language

- **Complaining:** *I am writing about a matter related to . . .*
- **I have been meaning to:** I would like to bring to your attention ... that has been giving me difficulty/causing me concern.
- **To narrate an experience:** I would like to explain why . . .
- **I would be grateful if you would:** ...
- **I am writing to discuss:** *I am writing in connection with . . .*
- **I would like to express my gratitude:** *I would like to express my thanks to you for . . .*
- **I want you to be aware that:** *I feel I should tell you that . . .*
- **To state intention:** *I would be grateful if you could kindly . . .*
- **I am interested in the question of:** *I should be glad if you would . . .*
- **I would be glad if you could:** *I would be grateful if you could let me know . . .*
- **To apologise:** *I must apologise for . . .*
- **To ask someone to do (not do):** *I would be grateful if you could send me ... by the end of this week.*

Story

(For work on stories, see pages 40 and 151.)

Task

Your teacher has asked you to write a story for the school English language magazine. It can be about future or past events, for example (a day in the life, but more than that)./It must be from the point of view you are given. You should write **120–180 words**.

Model answer

We use time words to say when things happened, e.g. the last football game.

DON'T use a comma between the main clause and 'but'.

DO use a comma with 'but', if it is not followed by and.

DO try to extend your ideas. Don't just add 'and'.

Hi Daniel,

I wanted to do my best, but more than that I wanted the team's best. It was the last football game of the season, and if we won, we would be the champions. As we ran onto the pitch, the butterflies inside me rose. On the ends of our seats, but the opposition looked strong.

The game started. I got the ball and raced towards the goal. Oh no! I couldn't go on, but I looked up and I saw the hands of the coach. 'Pass!' they said. I did, and we lost the ball, but we won in the end.

When the crowd had settled, I had to tell my friends. After three years of waiting, celebrating had never felt sweeter. We went out until late everything feeling. My legs hurt. I was so sorry they didn't let me play the last game. When times were suddenly hard and low, you made us feel strong! Thank you. I'm so small were away! We were the champions!

Best wishes,
Luke

(176 words)

DON'T use ARE/IS with a plural subject. We use 'the opposition', so it is **looked**.

DO add also, either, neither, too, etc. to help your story.

DO use adverbs to give more detail to your story.

Useful language

- We use **adjectives** and adverbs to make good stories.
- **If or When?** Use the past tense in both if or when clauses. (unit 1 page 8)
- **Don'ts** or **verb** (e.g. do/don't doesn't like)
- **LINK IDEAS:** And, so (that), BUT, IF (unless), THEN (as a result)
- **PAST TIME WORDS:** next, soon, then, last week, yesterday, before that, in the end, at last, finally, etc.
- **A few/few/a little/little:** We use a few and a little with positive ideas and few and little with negative ideas.
- **We want someone to do something.** TOO (also, either, neither) We use too with positive ideas. We use either and neither with negative ideas.

Useful language

- Changing the tennis game was unusual and magical like a dream!
 - I **HAVE BEEN** waiting for this moment for as long as I can remember!
 - I'm not sure whether the best time of the game was the moment
 - I won the game or when I was embraced by my team.
 - I couldn't believe me!
 - I could feel the sweat/sweatshirt trickle down my face as I played hard.
 - I was over the moon/under the weather when I found out I had won the trophy.
 - **I WAS ON CLOUD NINE! I STILL AM!**
 - My coach was the key to my victory this year.
 - We achieved the **dream/dream** the impossible this season.
- You always have to try your best!

Task

You have arranged a letter from a pen friend when planning a two-week visit. You have a letter in your pen friend, describing the activities you have planned for him/her and a list with advice on what to bring and ask about any special requests. Write your letter. **Do not** write your postal address.

Informal letter

B

Sample answers

A

Dear Cathy,

Thanks for the letter you sent. I'm so surprised that you are on your way here soon. You mentioned a letter that you didn't receive yet good news!!!

Firstly, it is a would like to recommend that you please bring your sunscreen and your hat and anything else that you might need for activities. Secondly, as you already know we have a long weekend activities lined up for us. We have a great plan lined up for up. There is Water Taxi ride, a day out at Science World, Stanley Park trip, sky train ride to deep cove and so much more all planned for you.

Something I want to ask you about is your special dietary needs. I'm sorry you have to fill out those allergy/wheat free options. Anything else I need to know?

I can't wait to see you! Looking forward to your reply. Do let me know if there is anything else you want to know.

P.S, Looking forward to hearing from you again!

Talk soon,

Carol

Dear Diego,

Hi! How are you? Thank you so much! I am so happy about your post letter! Your letter made me so excited about the time we are going to spend. I have made a plan to plan to do the tourist visiting. There will be Stanley park trip, we will take of unless the Marine Environmental Station then the fun of the Science World.

I wonder about some sandwiches to mask the extensive letters to wandering who keen to do the so budget. All the times are fine and the good period of the time.

Do you park, please let me know? I'll be glad to.

I am look forward your replay and wish to meet you.

Take care.

Vinka

Comments

A This is a full answer to the question, with a range of good reasons and activities. There are a few grammatical mistakes (e.g. momentum instead of activities) and you could use a more natural way when asking your questions (for Americans more than for British people). Your language is good, especially in connecting words are well used and the way of explaining is clear in more than one way, a satisfying effort in the task!

Band 6

B and parts of the questions are dealt well, in an informal way. There are some grammatical mistakes (e.g. may be → maybe) and not all details have been covered (e.g. bring a pen and ask about bus times and restaurant choices) so you don't quite achieve as high a band. You have made a good attempt in the task, a positive effort on the result.

Band 6



Report

For work on reports, see pages 78 and 114.

Task

Your town's urban gym costs \$150,000 a year to run; some people say this money can be used best on improving the library. You have decided to write a report to the school to state the advantages of spending this money on improving the library instead of the gym. What should be done and why?

Write your **report**. Do not write any personal letters. **120–180 words**.

Useful language

- **Including ideas:** Furthermore, what's more, not only ...
 - **The report is intended to:** ...
 - **Describing results:** ...
 - **Giving views:** I think/feel that ...
 - **Several examples:** one example/demonstration is that ...
 - **Presenting a list:**
 - my main recommendations are:
 - my recommendations are: the following measures are recommended
 - **Making recommendations:**
 - I suggest/advise/propose that ...; we could ...
 - it is possible that ..., perhaps ... is a good idea
- Stating units or quantities: \$50,000, in dollars; in millions of ...

Model answer

Use of money for school improvements

Introduction

In this staff report, my aim is to investigate the advantages of spending our town's annual gym costs of \$150,000. I would like to suggest that this money should be invested in the improvement of the town library.

Surveys and/or comparisons

Some of the students I asked I feel the time we spend in the gym is unimportant; more useful to them is reading stories.

- It is rarely used
- People go there mainly to chat

However, opinion about the library varied: 98% said they found it useful and they go there regularly.

Improving the library

Much of the \$40,000 ordered in the association's survey on the library would be:

- more space for the library & space to study in small or group. The library will then be a quiet place for research or study. It is important for the good results of students.

Books to update

Books or records

They want to be able to read relevant books written for young people.

Recommendations

With many of your benefits, first the majority of students will really benefit from the library with more space and relevant books than the present gym.

(176 words)

(01) Give the report purpose: what the report aims to do.

(02) Include findings from comparison and/or survey.

(03) Include ideas about the results of the comparison.

(04) List the improvements you would like to see.

(05) Give your views about the results, why they are important or what they mean.

(06) Give your reasons for the improvements.

(07) List possible improvements in detail.

(08) Make your recommendation/conclusion.

Article

For work on articles, see pages 30, 132 and 126.

Task

You saw this advertisement in a local English language newspaper.

Hey! magazine is looking for articles written by teenagers for our special summer edition. What do you think makes a successful magazine article? Let us know!

Write your article. (You should write between 130–180 words.)

Useful language

Including the reader

- Always include the reader in your article. How will you address him?

Choosing a title/snappy start

- Choose a title which will attract readers, e.g. why not use a graphic, woho.

Rhetorical questions

- The reader will already be thinking about the answer ...
- Developing ideas in separate paragraphs

One idea or feeling

Giving examples of the example you have chosen, or use evidence to support it.

- **Keeping to the point**

The reader is not interested in your life history, so don't ramble on.

- **Ending**

It should be a strong end. Why not finish with a question or a suggestion your reader can think about?

Model answer

It's a good idea to attract readers by having a snappy and interesting title.

Give reasons for your points.

Use specific examples to illustrate your points.

Organise your article with clear development of ideas.

End your article with a thought-provoking question.

Ghosts around – earning for revenge

When most people think of ghosts, they think of those blood-curdling stories you always hear in horror films. But in fact it is not only in films that ghosts exist – they do exist and they are looking for revenge on criminals that didn't get what they deserved.

I always think it's important to explain why someone wants revenge. Ghosts are usually the people who were victims of horrible, senseless murders, accidents and disasters. Finding out what exactly was their last sight on Earth helps the reader to imagine exactly what their life was like.

In most ghost stories, the end is always about the chase. What are they looking for, what is the ultimate goal, what is stopping them from reaching their goal? Most of the time you can easily guess what they're after.

In most stories, the ghosts get what they're looking for; sometimes they don't, and it's always a shock to the reader.

So, what do you think? Are YOU ready for revenge?

Do you explain in your introduction what the article is about, and how it is important and interesting to the reader?

Do you develop your ideas in separate paragraphs?

Do you keep to your main point?

Do you end with a thought-provoking question?

(179 words)

Writing reference (Paper 2)

Email / alternative transactional writing form

For work on emails, see pages 52, 133 and 134.

Task

You are going to write an email in response to a given situation.

Write your email. (You should write between 120–180 words).

Hi! You have received this email from your English-speaking friend, Tom.
Read your email carefully and write your reply.

Model answer

Start with a friendly greeting. Use the person's name.

Thank the person for their email.

Answer the first point in the email.

Answer the second point in the email.

Answer the third point and give your opinion.

Use a friendly closing.

Hi Tom!

Thanks for your email! It was great to hear from you and to find out what's new.

You asked about the course I'm doing. It's a photography course that I started last month. There are ten students in my group and we have lessons every Saturday morning.

You also wanted to know how I'm enjoying it. I really love it! The teacher is excellent, and I'm learning lots of useful skills. Last week we went on a city walk to take photos, which was really interesting and fun.

As for the exhibition, I think it's a fantastic idea. We could choose a central place in town where lots of people can see it. I'd be happy to help you organise it.

Write back soon and let me know your ideas!

Best wishes,
Alex

(156 words)

Useful language

Greeting and closing

- Use an appropriate greeting (e.g. Hi Tom!, Hello Sarah!, and closing (e.g. Best wishes. See you soon).

Inform your normal tone

- Use friendly, natural language. Avoid very formal phrases.

- Answer every part of the prompt

- Make sure you respond to all the questions or points in the email.

Paraphrasing

- Start a new paragraph for each main point. This makes your email clear and easy to read.

Linking words

- Use linking words and phrases to connect your ideas (e.g., First of all, Also, That's why, Finally).

Check your email

- Check spelling, grammar and punctuation. Make sure your email is clear and correctly organised.

DO

Reply to every part of the email.

DON'T

Leave out any questions or information.

DO

Use clear paragraphs for each main point.

DON'T

Write one long paragraph.

DO

Use linking words (e.g., also, as for, that's why, finally).

DON'T

Use the same connectors repeatedly.

Useful language

Opening an email

- Hi (Name).
- Hello (Name).
- Dear (Name).
- Thanks for your email!

Making requests

- Could you ?
- Can you ... ?
- I'd be grateful if you could ...
- Do you think you could ... ?

Giving advice

- I think you should ...
- Why don't you ?
- It might be a good idea to ...
- I recommend ...

Making arrangements

- How about ... ?
- Shall we ... ?
- Let's ...
- What time shall we ... ?

Closing an email

- Write back soon.
- Will look forward to hearing from you.
- See you soon.
- Be more friendly, make care,
- All the best,

Story

For work on stories, see pages 78 and

114.

Task

Write a story.

Your story must begin with this sentence: I didn't want to get involved, but in the end I had no choice.

Write your story in 140–190 words.

Useful narrative language

- **Setting the scene:** It was a cold, rainy evening when ...
- **Time phrases:** Suddenly, .../ Before I knew it, ...
- **Describing feelings:** I felt a wave of panic ...
- **Action verbs:** I ran, grabbed, whispered, hid ...
- **Dialogue:** "Help!" she shouted.
- **Linking ideas:** At that moment, .../ Just then, ...
- **Ending:** In the end, I realised that ...

Model answers

A) The Lost Wallet

Opening uses the given sentence naturally.

Clear events in time order.

Direct speech adds interest.

Strong ending with reflection.

I didn't want to get involved, but in the end I had no choice. I was walking home after football practice when I saw a man drop his wallet outside the shop. I looked around. Nobody else had noticed. Part of me thought, "It's not my problem." But then I remembered how upset I would feel if I lost my wallet.

I ran after him and called out. He stopped and looked surprised. When I gave him the wallet, his face lit up. Inside was a lot of cash and his ID.

He thanked me over and over and offered me some money. I didn't take it. Walking home, I felt proud. I didn't want to get involved, but in the end I had no choice—and it was the right decision.

B) The Hidden Door

Opening creates mystery.

Builds tension with short sentences.

Descriptive language adds atmosphere.

Ending is clear and satisfying.

I didn't want to get involved, but in the end I had no choice. We were exploring the old house at the edge of town when I noticed a door behind a pile of boxes. My friends wanted to walk away, but I felt something pulling me closer.

I pushed the door. It creaked open. Inside was a small room filled with old letters and photos. Suddenly, I heard footsteps. We froze.

An old man appeared, "Who are you?" he asked. We explained that I hadn't meant to intrude. He sighed, then smiled. "It's been years since anyone showed interest." He told us the house had once belonged to his family.

When we left, the sun was setting. I realized that curiosity can lead to unexpected stories—and sometimes to new friendships.

(176 words)

Examiner comments (Band 4)

Strengths

- Clear plot with a good sequence of events.
- Uses direct speech and feelings.
- Good range of simple and some complex sentences.

To improve

- Add more descriptive language.
- Use a wider range of past forms (e.g., was looking, had dropped).
- Vary sentence openings more.

Examiner comments (Band 5)

Strengths

- Engaging and well-structured plot.
- Good use of atmosphere and detail.
- Variety of sentence structures.
- Meaningful ending.

To improve

- Use a few more complex sentences.
- Expand description of setting and character.
- Check punctuation in dialogue.

Story checklist

Plot	Paragraph	Grammar	A&	Reader impact
Clear beginning, middle and end Events in time order Problem and resolution	New paragraph for new event or idea Logical flow Not too many short paragraphs	Mostly past tense Mix of simple and complex sentences Correct punctuation (... , ? !) etc.	Varied and appropriate words Descriptive language Linking words (e.g., then, suddenly)	Engages the reader Shows feelings and reactions Memorable ending

Top tip: Plan your story in 2–3 minutes: setting, main events, turning point, ending. Then write, leaving time to check your work.



Informal letter

For work on letters, see pages 78 and 114.

Task

Write a letter to a friend.

Your letter must answer all the questions.

Write your letter in 120–180 words.

Model opening and closing

Openings

- Hi [name],
- Hey!
- Dear [name],
- Hi there,
- Hello [name],
- Guess what?

Closings

- Write back soon!
- Looking forward to hearing from you.
- Take care!
- Lots of love,
- See you soon,
- All the best,
- Speak soon,
- Love,

Useful language

- Greetings: Hi [name], / Hey! / Dear [name],
- Friendly tone: I hope you're well. / How are things?
- Responding to every prompt: Thanks for your email.
Let me answer your questions.
- Asking & answering questions: What about you? / How about you?
- To answer your question, ...
- Making suggestions: How about ...? / Why don't we ...?
- Expressing feelings: I'm really happy that ...
- I was a bit worried when ...
- Linking ideas: Also, ... / By the way, ... / Anyway, ...
- Well, ... / So, ...
- Closings: Write back soon! / Looking forward to hearing from you. / Take care!

How to write a great informal letter

Start warmly.

Use a friendly greeting and an opening sentence to show interest.

Answer everything.

Make sure you respond to all the points in the task.

Ask and answer questions.

Keep the conversation going by asking your friend about them.

Make suggestions.

Offer ideas or plans to keep your letter interesting and friendly.

Share feelings.

Talk about how you feel about the events or your friend's news.

Link your ideas.

Use linking words to connect your sentences and ideas clearly.

End naturally.

Use a suitable closing to finish your letter on a friendly note.

Example links and phrases

- Also, ...
- By the way, ...
- Anyway, ...
- Well, ...
- So, ...
- That reminds me, ...
- I can't wait to ...
- Thanks again for ...
- Let me know if ...
- Can't wait to hear from you!

Final checklist

DO

- ✓ Use a friendly, personal tone.
- ✓ Answer all the questions in the task.
- ✓ Ask your friend a question or two.
- ✓ Use a good range of vocabulary.
- ✓ Use linking words to connect ideas.
- ✓ Check spelling, punctuation and word count.

DON'T

- Don't use a formal style.
- Don't ignore any part of the task.
- Don't write short or disappointing answers.
- Don't repeat the same vocabulary.
- Don't forget to link your ideas.
- Don't exceed the word limit.

Tap tip: Plan your letter in 2–3 minutes: greeting, answers, questions, feelings, suggestions and closing. Then write and leave time to check your work.

Report

Here are two sample answers and examiner comments for a typical FCE Writing (Paper 2) task.

Task

You see this announcement in your school magazine.

IDEAS WANTED!

We are looking for ideas for improving the school facilities.

Write a report for the school magazine saying what facilities students use, what improvements are needed, and what you recommend.

Write your report in 120–180 words.

Useful language

Headings

- Introduction • Facilities used • Findings
- Comparisons • Recommendations • Conclusion
- Finding
- Most students use ...
- Most majority of ...
- A small number of ...
- One issue is ...
- Another problem is ...
- Comparisons
- Compared with ... , ...
- More students prefer ... than ...
- The most popular ... is ...
- Recommendations
- I recommend that
- It would be good idea to ...
- We should consider ...
- This would help to ...

Sample answer 1

Introduction: This report summarises the results of a survey about school facilities and suggests improvements.

Facilities used: The most used facilities are the library, the sports hall and the computer room. Over 80% of students use the library every week, and around 70% use the computer room regularly. The computer room is used by 60% of students.

Findings: One issue is that the dining area is too small and often crowded. Another problem is that there are not enough computers for all students. A small number of students said the Wi-Fi connection is slow.

Comparisons: Compared with last year, more students now use the sports hall, but fewer use the computer room.

Recommendations: I recommend that the school expands the dining area and buys more computers. It would also be a good idea to improve the Wi-Fi.

Conclusion: These improvements would make school life better for everyone.

Examiner comments (Band 4)

Organisation: Well-organised with clear headings and logical flow.

Register: Appropriate and formal throughout.

Recommendations: Clear and realistic suggestions.

Grammar: Good range of structures with few errors.

Vocabulary: Good range of topic vocabulary; mostly accurate.

Sample answer 2

Introduction: The survey asked students about the school facilities and how they could be improved.

Facilities used: Most students use the library and the sports field. About half of them use the computer room.

Findings: Many students think the canteen is too small. There are not enough seats also, some students say the classrooms are too hot in summer.

Campaigns: More students use the library than the computer room.

Recommendations: We should make the canteen bigger and add more seats. It is also a good idea to put fans in the classrooms.

Conclusion: These changes would help students feel more comfortable at school.

Examiner comments (Band 3)

Organisation: Basic organisation; some parts are not very detailed.

Register: Generally appropriate, with occasional informal phrases.

Recommendations: Simple but relevant suggestions.

Grammar: Some errors with articles and prepositions.

Vocabulary: Adequate range; some repetition.

Final checklist for a report

- ☒ Use clear headings.
- ☒ Describe the situation and present the findings.
- ☒ Compare information where possible.
- ☒ Make practical recommendations.
- ☒ Use formal language and third person.

- ☒ Use a range of linking words.
- ☒ Check grammar, spelling and punctuation.
- ☒ Keep within the word limit (120–180 words).
- ☒ Read through your report before you submit it.

Article

Here are two sample answers and examiner comments for a typical FCE Writing (Paper 2) task.

Task

Your teacher has asked you to write an article for the school magazine.

TOPIC: SCREEN TIME

Write an article for your school magazine about the impact of screen time on teenagers.

Include the following points:

- how much time teenagers spend on screens
- the positive and negative effects
- some advice for using screens in a healthy way

Write your article in 120–180 words.

Useful language

Engaging the reader

- Have you ever noticed ... ?
- Let's face it, ...
- It's hard to imagine life without ...
- Introducing opinions
- There's no doubt that ...
- On the one hand ... On the other hand ...
- Why should it be beneficial, ...
- Adding emphasis
- The truth is ...
- What's more ...
- In fact, ...
- Giving advice
- So much can we do? ...
- A good place to start is ...
- Remember, balance is the key.
- Concluding
- In the end, ...
- Ultimately, ...
- It's up to us to ...

Sample article 1

Too Much Screen Time?

Have you ever noticed how glued are we to screens? From phones and laptops to tablets and TVs, teenagers now spend much of their day online.

On average, many of us spend four to six hours a day on screens. The good news is that screens offer amazing opportunities. We can learn new things, keep in touch with friends and be entertained. In fact, online lessons and videos can make studying more interesting and flexible.

However, there's a down side. There's much screen time can lead to tired eyes, poor sleep and less exercise. What's more, it can affect our mood and make us feel amazed or bored. We'll prepare ourselves to others online.

So, what can we do? A good place to start is setting daily limits and taking regular breaks. Try to switch off notifications, avoid screens before bed and spend more time on hobbies or outdoors.

In the end, screens aren't the enemy. Used wisely, they can help us learn, connect and grow. It's up to us to find the right balance.

Examiner comments (Band 4)

Engaging the reader: Effective opening question that immediately involves the reader.

Title and opening: Clear, relevant and attention-grabbing.

Paragraph development: Well-organised paragraphs with clear ideas and examples.

Rhetorical questions: Used successfully in the opening to engage.

Register: Appropriate and friendly for a school magazine.

Vocabulary: Good range of topic vocabulary (e.g. glued, opportunities, notifications).

Ending: Strong convincing sentence with a positive, reflective note.

Sample article 2

Screens: Friend or Foe?

Let's face it, screens are everywhere. But how much time is too much?

Most teenagers spend around five hours a day on screens. While this can help with schoolwork and staying connected, it can also cause problems. Sitting for long periods may lead to headaches, poor posture and less exercise. Do we really want to risk our health for endless scrolling?

The good news is that we can take control. Plan screen-free times, especially during meals and before bed. Instead of reaching for your phone, why not read a book, play a sport or meet friends in person? Remember, small changes can make a big difference. Balance your online and offline life. Your future self will thank you!

Examiner comments (Band 3)

Engaging the reader: Good use of rhetorical question in the introduction.

Title and opening: Appropriate and relevant, though slightly less original.

Paragraph development: Clear ideas, but examples could be more developed.

Rhetorical questions: Used once effectively.

Register: Suitable for teenagers.

Vocabulary: Adequate range; some repetition (e.g. screens, time).

Ending: Positive and encouraging, though quite brief.

Final checklist for an article

- | | | | |
|-------------------------------------|---|-------------------------------------|--|
| ☒ | Use an engaging title and opening. | ☒ | Use a friendly, appropriate register. |
| ☒ | Include all the points from the task. | ☒ | Use a range of vocabulary and linking words. |
| ☒ | Develop ideas with examples and details. | ☒ | End with a strong, positive or reflective message. |
| ☒ | Use rhetorical questions to involve the reader. | ☒ | Check spelling, punctuation and word limit. |

Tap tip: Hook your reader early, develop your ideas clearly and end with impact.
Keep it interesting, relevant and easy to read.

Email / alternative transactional writing

Here are two sample answers and examiner comments for a typical FCE Writing (Paper 2) task.

Task

You see this message on an English-language website.

MESSAGE:

We are organising a weekend volunteer project to improve a local nature reserve. If you are interested, email us and tell us:

- why you want to help
- what skills or experience you have
- what dates you are available

Write your email in 120-150 words.

Useful language

Making requests

- I would be grateful if you could ...
- Could you please let me know ?
- I'd appreciate it if ...

Giving advice / showing interest

- In my opinion, ...
- I think it's a good idea to ...
- I'd really like to ...

Making arrangements

- I'm available from ... to ...
- Does ... work for you?
- Let me know if that's OK.

Sign offs

- Looking forward to hearing from you.
- Please get back to me soon.
- Best regards, / Kind regards,

Sample email 1

Subject: Weekend volunteer project

Dear Organiser,
I am very interested in taking part in your weekend volunteer project at the nature reserve. I want to have because I care about the environment and I believe small efforts to make a big difference. I enjoy being outdoors and I think it would be a great way to meet like-minded people.
I have some experience from school projects where we planted trees and cleaned local parks. I am also good at working in a team and I am happy to do any practical tasks you need, such as planting, collecting rubbish or painting.
I am available on the weekend of 14th-15th June. Please let me know if that date is suitable or if you need any more information from me.
Looking forward to hearing from you.
Danie
Best regards,

Examiner comments (Band 4)

Greeting & closing: Appropriate and friendly.

Tone: Positive, polite and shows real interest.

Answering every prompt: All three points (why, skills/experience, availability) are clearly covered.

Paragraphing: Well-organised into clear paragraphs.

Accuracy: Generally accurate with only minor errors.

Vocabulary: Good range (e.g. environment, difference, practical tasks, suitable).

Sample email 2

Subject: Volunteering at the nature reserve

Hello,

I'd like to join the weekend volunteer project you are organising. I'm interested because I love nature and I think it's important to protect wild places for the future. It would also be a good opportunity to learn new things and help my local community.

I have some experience from volunteering and I am also working and I learn quickly. I often help my family with gardening and I'm comfortable using basic tools. I'm also reliable and I always arrive on time.

I can come on either 21st or 22nd June. If those dates aren't possible, please let me know and I'll see what I can do.
Thanks for considering my email.
Kind regards,
Sophie

Examiner comments (Band 3)

Greeting & closing: Clear and appropriate.

Tone: Friendly and positive.

Answering every prompt: All points answered, though details are a little brief.

Paragraphing: Uses paragraphs but could be more developed.

Accuracy: Mostly correct with some minor mistakes.

Vocabulary: Adequate (e.g. protect, community, reliable).

Final checklist for an email

- Use a clear subject line.
- Include a suitable greeting and closing.
- Answer every point in the task.
- Organise your ideas into short paragraphs.

- Use a polite and appropriate tone.
- Use a range of vocabulary and linking words.
- Check spelling, punctuation and verb forms.
- End with a friendly, positive note.

Tap tip: Plan your ideas first, keep your email focused and easy to read, and always check your work before you send it!



Proposal

Here are two sample answers and examiner comments for a typical FCE Writing (Paper 2) task.

Task

You see this proposal request from your local community centre.

PROPOSAL REQUEST:

The community centre wants to improve activities for teenagers in the local area. Write a proposal for the centre director with ideas about:

- what activities could be offered
- how they would benefit teenagers
- how the centre could promote them

Write your proposal.
Write your proposal in 120-150 words.

Useful language

Describing problems

- There are few ...
- Teenagers have limited opportunities to ...
- Many young people feel ...

Suggesting improvements

- We could introduce ...
- It would be a good idea to ...
- Another option would be to ...

Giving reasons

- This would help because ...
- As a result, teenagers would ...
- It would encourage ...

Making recommendations

- I recommend that we ...
- I believe the best solution is ...
- I suggest we should ...

Sample proposal 1

Subject: Activities for teenagers

I would like to suggest several ideas to improve activities for teenagers at our community centre.

First, we could offer a weekly sports club with football and basketball sessions. This would help teenagers stay active, build confidence and make new friends.

Second, we could run workshops such as cooking, photography and music. These activities would allow young people to discover new interests and develop useful skills.

To promote these activities, I recommend creating posters for local schools and sharing information on social media. We could also invite teenagers to help them with the process.

In my opinion, these ideas would attract more teenagers and create a positive, welcoming environment. Thank you for considering my proposal.

Alex

Sample proposal 2

I am writing to propose some new activities that could make our community centre more appealing to teenagers.

To begin with, I could introduce a homework help club in the afternoons. This would support students with their studies and reduce stress.

In addition, I suggest organising a monthly talent night for teenagers can perform a competition for the best. It would give them a chance to express themselves and gain confidence.

Finally, to promote these activities, we could partner with local youth organisations and offer trial words. Word of mouth would also help.

Overall, I believe these activities would benefit teenagers by giving them a safe place to learn, relax and socialise.

I look forward to hearing your thoughts.

Yours sincerely,

Maya

Examiner comments

Comments on Sample proposal 1

Organisation: Clear structure with an introduction, ideas, promotion and conclusion.

Headings: Not used, which is fine for a short proposal.

Recommendations: 'Well-developed ideas with clear benefits.

Register: Appropriate and professional throughout.

Grammar: Good range of tenses and complex sentences.

Vocabulary: Useful topic-related words (e.g. workshops, promote, welcoming).

Reader impact: Easy to read and convincing in practical suggestions.

Comments on Sample proposal 2

Organisation: Logical order with three main ideas and a conclusion.

Headings: Not used, but ideas are well separated.

Recommendations: Relevant suggestions with clear reasons.

Register: Polite and suitable for a formal audience.

Grammar: Mostly accurate with some complex structures.

Vocabulary: Good range of appropriate words (e.g. organise, partner, socialise).

Reader impact: Engaging and shows consideration of teenagers' needs.

Useful language for proposals

• Describing problems
Teenagers lack opportunities to ...
There are not enough ...
Many young people feel ...

• Suggesting improvements
We could introduce ...
It would be a good idea to ...
Another option would be ...

• Giving reasons
This would help because ...
As a result, it would ...
It would encourage ...

• Making recommendations
I recommend that we ...
I believe the best solution is ...
I suggest we should ...



Writing Paper 2: final checklist

Use this checklist to review your work before you hand it in.

1		Task achievement Did I write the right type of text (proposal)? Did I answer every point in the task? Did I include reasons, examples and a recommendation?
2		Organisation Is my text clearly structured (introduction, ideas, conclusion)? Are my ideas in a logical order? Do I use paragraphs to separate my ideas?
3		Register and tone Is my tone appropriate and polite? Do I use formal language and avoid contractions? Do my writing sound respectful and professional?
4		Vocabulary Have I used a good range of topic-related vocabulary? Have I avoided repetition by using synonyms or paraphrases? Is my vocabulary accurate and natural?
5		Grammar Have I used a mix of simple and complex sentences? Are my verb forms, tenses and word order correct? Are my articles, prepositions and plurals correct?
6		Paragraph Does each paragraph have a clear topic sentence? Do the sentences in each paragraph support the main idea? Are my ideas well linked within and between paragraphs?
7		Word count Is my proposal between 120 and 150 words? Have I checked the word count?
8		Proofreading Have I checked spelling, punctuation and capital letters? Have I corrected any mistakes in grammar or word forms? Is my handwriting clear and easy to read?
9		Every prompt Have I responded to all the points in the task? Did I include at least two ideas, reasons and a recommendation?

Self-assessment: ask yourself

Have I written a complete proposal, not notes?
Would the reader understand my ideas easily?
Are my reasons and examples relevant and convincing?
Have I used a variety of sentence types?
Does my conclusion summarise my ideas and give a clear recommendation?

Does my writing match the style of a formal proposal for a community centre?
Would this text persuade the centre director?
If I had more time, what one thing would I improve?
Am I confident this is my best work?